The Maasai Rites of Passage Are Changing. So Is How They Are Remembered

How a generation carrying smartphones, university schedules, and traditional obligations is experiencing Enkipaata, Eunoto, and Olng'esherr differently.

Daniel Uka has no backup when it comes to Memory.

Daniel is in his late 50s and is a member of the ageset (Ilkisarru) of Ilkishili men, considered one age. On the days he thinks of his Enkipaata (the pre-initiation rite), he remembers dust, thousands of boys, the voices going over the bush.

The boys walked for days, under the tutelage of the elders, at the communal ceremonial site at Olmesutie. Their mothers and the elders built them and prepared the boys for their duties.

Daniel recalls the day he realized that his childhood was coming to an end.

He was no longer just the boy of his father. He was now in an ageset.

The elders taught them to respect each other (enkanyit) and to stand together.

Daniel remembers learning that “A Maasai warrior does not stand alone.” “When one falls, the age-set falls.”

No Smartphones were recording the journey. No WhatsApp group set up to organize participants. No electronic archive to go back to years later.

Daniel says, “Memory could only exist in our minds and in our songs.

Now, another generation is following in Daniel's footsteps, decades later, and they have one thing in their pocket that Daniel never had: A smartphone.

The initiation into manhood.

Maasai rites of passage are not just age-marking ceremonies. Enkipaata, Eunoto, and Olng'esherr are three steps in a process in which generations take on responsibilities and cultural knowledge.

For his generation, it was mostly a bodily transfer.

Enkipaata, boys from the same olporror would meet at Olmesutie. Daniel recalls that there were thousands of them walking through the land in large groups, singing and wearing loose cloaks.

The elders blessed them and imparted their values to the generation.

The boys were also subjected to the rigors of the trip.

It was a challenge for Daniel to prove his strength. It was the start of a sense of community.

The boys came back after Enkipaata with new expectations. They were no longer regarded as children. They were the ones who were considered to be the next generation.

Next came Eunoto, the passage from warriorhood.

Daniel's Olkisarui olporror met at Entasekera and worked on constructing a large warrior settlement (emanyatta). There were their mothers as well.

His happiest Memory is when he got his warriors' hair cut.

When his mother raised the razor, Daniel says, he cried silently.

It was like a goodbye.

However, following the shaving, the elders put red ochre and animal fat on their bodies. Daniel speaks of this as a transposition of one power into another.

The lessons were also modified.

They were taught to settle their disputes with wisdom and not with spears. They were introduced to the subject of marriage, clan laws, and peacekeeping.

The roles also evolved.

They were able to marry, build their own homestead, and own cattle on their own.

Years passed, and then came Olng'esherr.

That was the time when youth was gone, and elderhood had taken its place.

The other men of his olporror at Nkopon came together with their wives and senior elders, Daniel reports. Some of the cattle were chosen for slaughter, and the men took part in the sacred feast of the meat.

Daniel recalls spending his childhood on his grandfather's stool, olkiika, having grown up around men he had journeyed with through a lifetime.

He knew that their journey, which started as boys, had brought them to leadership.

The elders gave them more responsibilities and knowledge of their culture.

Daniel recalls the message vividly: “You are now the guardians of the culture; do not let it perish.”

That was a job that relied a great deal on people remembering what had been taught and passing it on to the next generation.

The term "remembering" takes on a new flavor for the next generation.

A new generation comes in a new way.

Leshao Legei is a member of the Nyangulo olpor of the 20s.

His generation is still meeting today at Olmesutie for Enkipaata and Entasekera for Eunoto. However, unlike Daniel's generation, many of his contemporaries have multiple lives.

Some are students at universities.

Others are employed in Nairobi.

Others stay in the rural countryside of homesteads.

Some were required to take a break from school or from their jobs to attend their ceremonies.

Leshao says it's a meeting of two worlds.

During the ceremony, he could be barefoot, covered in red ochre, and participating in traditional dances with his age-mates.

From there, he would be able to move to a corner of the bush where he could receive a good signal and view his university exam results.

It was a strange blend of old dust and new fear, he says.

The difference is that his generation has not abandoned the rites.

What it is, it's that now the rites must fit around lives that extend beyond the ceremonial landscape.

Daniel recalls a time when his generation could stay out in the bush until the elders called it a day.

The generation of Leshao has semesters to finish and jobs to go back to.

For my grandparents, the bush was all they knew, he says, "for me it's a choice."

He claims that the ceremonies are now shorter.

However, there is still a psychological value.

Transition is still very significant.

The olporror is still important.

And the teachings of the elders are still here.

Leshao recalls being told, “Go to school, get your degrees, go to the digital world, but never forget that you are a Nyangulo warrior first.

It's not necessarily against modernity.

It is trying to make space for both worlds.

The ceremony is now starting on WhatsApp.

Technology doesn't always start as soon as the first smartphone is introduced at the ceremony.

For Leshao, it starts much earlier.

His age mates in different towns use WhatsApp groups to do preparations. Before they meet in person, they talk about logistics, solicit funds, and maintain communication.

The phone brings families and age-mates closer together if they no longer live in the same house.

Mobile money is also used to transfer funds from Nairobi to those organizing the event at home.

In this regard, technology isn't taking the place of the ceremony. It's aiding in its organization.

The same mobile device that enables a university student to stay connected with city life can also help to bring him back into the cultural life of his hometown.

However, as the ceremony starts, the phone's purpose changes.

It turns into a camera.

Leshao remembers the traditional dances taking place alongside the clicking cameras and smartphones.

In Daniel's generation, documentation was limited. In Leshao, almost everyone has access to a camera.

Professional Maasai digital creators can be hired to produce high-definition videos.

Participants can record their age-mates.

Relatives who were not present can later see what happened.

And sometimes the audience extends far beyond the community.

Leshao says videos of their Eunoto, including performances of the traditional adumu jumping dance, were posted on TikTok.

A ceremony that once existed primarily within a community can now appear on the screens of people who have never set foot in Entasekera.

That creates a new tension.

For young people, sharing their culture online can be a source of pride.

But the wider the audience becomes, the harder it becomes to control where cultural images travel.

The question is no longer how do we remember this?

It is also: Who gets to see the Memory?

When the phone becomes a cultural textbook

Technology is also changing how some young people prepare for the rites themselves.

Leshao says some city-raised young men have watched YouTube recordings of previous age-sets to familiarise themselves with dance steps and songs before attending ceremonies.

That creates an unusual reversal.

The young person who has spent much of his life away from the traditional environment can use digital technology to reconnect with it.

Daniel's generation learned through elders, physical participation, stories, and songs.

Leshao's generation can learn through those things and through screens.

But the two forms of learning are not necessarily interchangeable.

A video can show a dance.

It cannot reproduce the experience of standing among an olporror, receiving instruction from an elder, or assuming the responsibilities that come with the transition.

And not everything should become content.

Daniel says his generation received deeper teachings about spirituality, prayer, and governance as they entered elderhood. Some cultural knowledge is not intended for unrestricted public circulation.

That makes digitization more complicated than simply recording something before it disappears.

A phone can preserve a memory.

It can also move that Memory beyond the people who created it.

The people carrying culture are changing too

The transformation isn't limited to phones.

The people participating in the rites are living different lives.

A young man can be a university student in Nairobi and a member of a rural olporror.

He can spend months studying or working away from home and then return to participate in a ceremony that connects him to generations before him.

That creates a different understanding of responsibility.

For Daniel, passing Eunoto meant entering a stage where building a homestead, marrying, and owning cattle were central responsibilities.

For Leshao's generation, those responsibilities have expanded.

He describes adulthood as balancing family obligations, education, employment, and cultural duties.

Leshao remembers being told: “Go to school, get your degrees, go to the digital world, but never forget that you are a Nyangulo warrior first.”

It is not necessarily a rejection of modernity.

It is an attempt to make room for both worlds.

What happens when culture gets a digital memory?

For generations, the transmission of Maasai cultural knowledge depended on people.

An elder taught.

A younger person listened.

An ageset (olporror) experienced something together.

Songs were remembered.

Stories were repeated.

Responsibilities were inherited.

The knowledge lived inside the community.

Now there is another place where some of that Memory can live: the phone.

A ceremony can be organized through WhatsApp, contributions sent through M-Pesa, moments recorded on smartphones, and performances shared on TikTok.

Young people living away from home can remain connected to their older relatives.

Someone who missed a ceremony can watch it later.

Someone preparing to participate can see how previous generations performed.

Technology has therefore created possibilities that Daniel's generation did not have.

But it has also introduced questions they never had to answer.

What should be recorded?

Who should see it?

Who controls it after it leaves the ceremonial ground?

And perhaps most importantly: Can recording culture preserve it without changing the way people experience it?

There is no simple answer.

The rites are still experienced in physical spaces. Elders still teach. Age-mates still gather. Young people still dance, sing, and take on new responsibilities.

But the world around those traditions is no longer the world Daniel knew as a boy.

For him, Memory lived in people.

For Leshao's generation, it increasingly lives in people and devices.

The smartphone has not replaced the elder.

But it has become another participant in the journey between generations.

And for a culture whose elders once told young men, “Do not let it die,” the question may no longer be only whether the next generation will remember.

It may be how and who gets to control what is remembered.